



What is the Chishtiya Silsila?

It is an Islamic Sufi order with heavy mystical leanings. Its most famous Sufis in India include Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti or Khwaja Gharib Nawaz whose mausoleum at Ajmer is perhaps the most famous shrine of a Chishtiya saint in India. Sufi mysticism is by no means confined to the sub-continent. It is a tradition with revered Sufis and their adherents to be found in almost every part of the Islamic world. There are four silsilas—Qadariya, Chishtiya, Suhrawardiya and Naqshbandiya. There aren't many fundamental differences among them. They are all within the framework of the Islamic law as laid down by the Quran and expounded by the Hadith but the rituals for obtaining communion with God are different. The Chishtiya Silsila follows the Sunni Hanafi school of jurisprudence.

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in 2007 as the locals refused to be a part of the event, says Khanooni's aide Rambabu Katara, a Brahmin.

A London-trained lawyer who gave up his Supreme Court practice to take up the seat, Khanooni is the vice-president of the National Sufi Board, an organisation of prominent heads of Sufi shrines across the country. The Board itself is a platform for Chishtiyyas to run an outreach programme through seminars and symposia. During the Urs at the Dargah in Gwalior last year, the seminar at-

TRIDENT-WIELDING SADHUS WITH SUFI CHISHTIYAS AT THE UPPER LAKE IN BHOPAL (TOP); CHADAR-POSHI AT A DARGAH IN GWALIOR

tracted wide attention with speakers like Sufi Asgar Ali from Indore.

There are others as well. Delhi-based Jamiyat-us-Sufiya, Haridwar-based Sufi Sant Samaj and Hyderabad-based Jamiyat-ul-Madaar are working on similar lines to preserve their brand of Islam. While other prominent Muslim sects like Shias and even Sunni sub-sects like Deo-

bandis, Barelvis or Nadvis work through well-defined and organised institutions. Sufis have traditionally been allied to their dargahs. Nation-wide organisations are helping them overcome the lack of a framework to propagate their message.

In Madhya Pradesh, the Muslim Tehwar Committee has never buckled under the pressure of hardliners, organising rambunctious, night-long functions for festivals like Shab-e-Baraat, something that the puritans abhor. Its event in May-end at the Dargah of Baba Fareed in Bhopal saw prominent Sikhs from the local Gurudwara Prabandhak Samiti lending a helping hand. Says the committee's president Ausaaf Shahmeeri Khurram, "We simply cannot allow our traditions to be transformed." But transforming they are. Whereas thirty years ago a prominent Sufi figure might have laughed off questions on religious identity, even the likes of Khanooni and Khurram are having to painstakingly explain that their devotion at a Sufi shrine is Ehteraam, not Ibadat, as the latter is reserved solely for the Almighty. Likewise, under the pressure of assault on their very identity as Muslims, they have set out lucid dos and don'ts on issues like idol-worship, one reason why even many Chishtiyyas among Muslims don't visit the shrine of Sai Baba in Shirdi any more.

That bolsters the critique that even Sufism is a one-way street, sufficiently diluted to suit the palate of other communities but unwilling to assimilate their strands. While the Chishtiya ideology is slowly reclaiming its space in its community, even a section of Hindus cast a suspicious eye on them. Prominent western Indologists as well as Indian scholars have attributed conversions in India to Islam over the centuries in large part to the drawing power of the Sufis. Says Kusumlata Kedia, a prominent voice on interfaith relations in the extended saffron brotherhood, "It is not quite the melting pot it is made out to be." Clearly, Sufism still has a long way to go before it becomes the great equaliser. ■